Ford Motor Company

James P. Vondale, Director
Automotive Safety Office
Environmental & Safety Engineering

February 13, 2001

Mr. Kenneth N. Weinstein
Associate Administrator for Safety Assurance
National Highway Traffic Safety Administration
400 Seventh Street, S.W.
Washington, D.C. 20590

Dear Mr. Weinstein:

Re: Ford Recall No. 01S06 – 2000 and 2001 Taurus Sedan Center High Mount Stop Lamps (CHMSL) and Brake Shift Interlock

Summary

- Ford Action - Ford is conducting a safety recall involving 2000 and 2001MY Taurus Sedans with factory or dealer installed deck lid spoilers with LED center high mounted stop lamps. The affected vehicles include those produced with spoilers from 3/1/2000 through 10/31/2000, and those with spoilers installed by dealers from 1/1/2000 through 12/30/2000.

- Number of Vehicles Involved - Approximately 28,000 vehicles; approximately 22,000 with factory installed spoilers and 6,000 with dealer installed spoilers.

- Affect on Vehicle Operation - With the ignition switch in the START or RUN positions and the hazard warning lights operating, the CHMSL illuminates (at reduced intensity) even though the service brakes have not been applied. Also, in some cases the vehicle brake-shift interlock may allow the shift lever to be moved from PARK without applying the brake.

- Safety Regulation Affected – The CHMSL illumination without brake application does not comply with Federal Motor Vehicle Safety Standard No. 108 that permits the CHMSL to be activated only when applying the service brakes. While not regulated, the operation of the brake shift interlock feature does not meet design intent.

- Service Procedure – Dealers will install a jumper/resistor assembly at the spoiler that provides an electrical resistor to ground and corrects the CHMSL and brake-shift interlock conditions.

Attached is the information required by the applicable portions of the Part 573 Defect and Non-compliance Information Report.

Sincerely,

James P. Vondale

Attachment
01S06.5d

Attachment
February 13, 2001

49 CFR PART 573 DEFECT AND NONCOMPLIANCE REPORT
01S06 - 2000 AND 2001 TAURUS SEDAN CENTER HIGH MOUNT STOP LAMP

Non-compliance Notification

Pursuant to Part 573 of Title 49 of the Federal Regulations, Defect and Noncompliance Reports, Ford Motor Company submits the following information concerning a safety-compliance field action that it is voluntarily initiating.

573.5 (c) (2) – Potentially affected vehicles

2000 and 2001 model year Taurus Sedans equipped with the deck lid mounted spoiler built at the Atlanta and Chicago Assembly Plants from March 1, 2000 through October 31, 2000, and 2000 and 2001 model year Taurus Sedans that had these spoilers installed by dealers from January 1, 2000 through December 30, 2000, are affected.

Because these vehicles are not produced in VIN order, information as to the applicability of this action to specific vehicles can best be obtained by either calling Ford's toll-free line (1-800-392-3673) or contacting a local Ford dealer, who can obtain specific information regarding the vehicles from the Ford On-line Automotive Service Information System (OASIS) database.

573.5 (c) (3) – Estimated population of vehicles potentially affected

Approximately 28,000 vehicles.

573.5 (c) (4) – Estimated percentage of affected vehicles with the defect condition

100 percent of the affected vehicles. These include those with factory installed spoilers produced from 3/1/2000 through 10/31/2000, and those with spoilers installed by dealers from 1/1/2000 through 12/30/2000.

573.5 (c) (5) – Description of the non-compliance

With the ignition key in the RUN or START positions, and the hazard lights turned ON, the spoiler mounted center high mounted stop lamp (CHMSL) on the affected vehicles is activated at reduced intensity without depressing the brake pedal. This condition does not satisfy the FMVSS 108 paragraph S5.5.4 requirement that specifies "the high mounted stop lamp on each vehicle shall be activated only upon application of the service brakes". In addition, under these same conditions, the brake-shift interlock in some cases can be circumvented, i.e., the shift lever can be shifted out of PARK without depressing the brake pedal.

This condition is caused by the electrical/electronics system design - an unintended voltage from the system electronic module exists across the spoiler LEDs when the ignition key is ON and the ground path through the stop lamps is removed (occurs when hazard switch is ON). This voltage at the LEDs is sufficient to illuminate these CHMLS LEDs at a reduced intensity without the brake pedal being depressed. This voltage also can energize the brake shift interlock solenoid, disengaging the locking mechanism, and allowing the shift lever to be moved out of PARK without depressing the brake pedal.

Ford is not aware of any reported accidents in the field related to this condition, or of any lawsuits or subrogation claims alleging accident or injury caused by this condition.

573.5 (c) (7) – Results/data indicating non-compliance

Ford's CAE lab testing (shared circuit analysis) of the brake circuit verified the existence of this condition. In addition, results of vehicle tests at both plants correlated with the CAE results confirming the condition.

573.5 (c) (8) – Service program

Ford will begin and complete notification to customers of affected vehicles on or about the week of March 19, 2001, requesting that they return their vehicles to dealers for installation of a jumper/resistor assembly at the spoiler to resolve the condition.

573.5 (c) (9) – Press statement

Ford does not, at this time, plan to issue a press release regarding this safety recall.

573.5 (c) (11) – Recall number

Ford has assigned recall number 01S06 to this action.